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Testing system with test rig

Abstract

A testing system and methods of testing interfaces of a subsystem are presented. The testing system is configured to test a subsystem prior to assembly into a system, the testing system comprising a test rig comprising electrical wiring and a mechanical restraint configured to emulate at least one physical specification of the structure; and a virtual software environment developed to emulate operating software for of the system.

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Background/Summary

BACKGROUND INFORMATION

1. Field

(1) The present disclosure relates generally to systems engineering and more specifically to a testing system and test rig for interface discovery in systems engineering.

2. Background

(2) Conventional systems engineering utilizes a V model. In the V model, design and decomposition of a system are performed first. After design, the components, and subsystems are procured and built. Testing is performed after design and building.

(3) An alternative to a conventional V model is an agile model. The agile model follows the same sequence as the systems V, but the V is performed for smaller pieces of the overall system. The agile development method performs several iterations of the systems V to complete a project.

(4) During testing in either the agile model or the V model, interface control documents for subsystems are developed and tested. Interface control documents describe the inputs and outputs of the subsystem. Documented interfaces serve as a foundation for system design. If a subsystem does not operate according to the interface control documents, the design of the system will need to be modified. Within the aerospace industry, interface non-conformances are often found in final build and test phases. The corrective actions for non-conformances during final assembly of an

aircraft or space vehicle can lead to an undesirable amount of unplanned time and expense.

(5) Therefore, it would be desirable to have a method and apparatus that takes into account at least some of the issues discussed above, as well as other possible issues.

SUMMARY

(6) An embodiment of the present disclosure provides a testing system configured to test a subsystem prior to assembly into a structure, the testing system comprises a test rig comprising electrical wiring and a mechanical restraint configured to emulate at least one physical specification of the structure; and a virtual software environment developed to emulate operating software for the system.

(7) Another embodiment of the present disclosure provides a method of testing a subsystem. Input is received at a virtual software environment to generate a command for the subsystem. The virtual software environment responsively generates a command to send to the subsystem. The output from the subsystem is received. It is determined if there is an inconsistency between the output from the subsystem and interface control documents of the subsystem.

(8) A further embodiment of the present disclosure provides a method of testing a subsystem prior to installation in a system. An interface control document for the subsystem is received. The subsystem is positioned onto a test rig configured to provide mechanical emulation of the system. Validation of the interface control document for the subsystem is performed using the test rig and a virtual software environment developed to emulate software for the system.

(9) A yet further embodiment of the present disclosure provides a method of system design for a system. Specifications for the system are received. Specifications for subassemblies of the system are developed from the specifications of the system. Validation of an interface control document of a subsystem to be used in the system is performed to determine modifications to one of the interface control document or a design for the system. The modifications are incorporated into at least one of the interface control document or the design for the system.

(10) The features and functions can be achieved independently in various embodiments of the present disclosure or may be combined in yet other embodiments in which further details can be seen with reference to the following description and drawings.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

(1) The novel features believed characteristic of the illustrative embodiments are set forth in the appended claims. The illustrative embodiments, however, as well as a preferred mode of use, further objectives and features thereof, will best be understood by reference to the following detailed description of an illustrative embodiment of the present disclosure when read in conjunction with the accompanying drawings, wherein:

(2) FIG. 1 is an illustration of a block diagram of a testing environment in which an illustrative embodiment may be implemented;

(3) FIG. 2 is an illustration of a block diagram of a testing environment in which an illustrative embodiment may be implemented;

(4) FIG. 3 is an illustration of a block diagram of a data flow of a virtual software environment in accordance with an illustrative embodiment;

(5) FIG. 4 is an illustration of a testing environment in accordance with an illustrative embodiment;

(6) FIGS. 5A and 5B are a flowchart of a method of validating an interface control document of a subsystem in accordance with an illustrative embodiment;

(7) FIG. 6 is a flowchart of operating a virtual software environment in accordance with an illustrative embodiment;

(8) FIG. 7 is a flowchart of a method of testing a subsystem in accordance with an illustrative

embodiment;

(9) FIG. **8** is a flowchart of a method of testing a subsystem prior to installation in a system in accordance with an illustrative embodiment;

(10) FIG. **9** is an illustration of a systems design flow with interface control document validation in accordance with an illustrative embodiment;

(11) FIG. **10** is a flowchart of a method of testing a subsystem prior to installation in a system in accordance with an illustrative embodiment;

(12) FIG. **11** is an illustration of an aircraft manufacturing and service method in a form of a block diagram in accordance with an illustrative embodiment; and

(13) FIG. **12** is an illustration of an aircraft in a form of a block diagram in which an illustrative embodiment may be implemented.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION

(14) The illustrative examples recognize and take into account one or more different considerations. The illustrative examples recognize and take into account that as systems become increasingly more sophisticated and complex, the methodologies for designing and integrating these systems should evolve to maintain high levels of first-time quality. The illustrative examples recognize and take into account that when integrating complex new subsystems into a complex system, the present state-of-the-art delays discovery of interface issues. The illustrative examples recognize and take into account that discovery of interface non-conformances prior to subsystem design would be desirable. The illustrative examples recognize and take into account that issues integrating complex new subsystems can lead to schedule delay to rework the design, or system delivery to a customer with undesirable quality. The illustrative examples recognize and take into account that issues integrating complex new subsystems can result in cost and schedule overruns.

(15) The illustrative examples present a testing system and methods for interface control document validation. The illustrative examples present processes of evaluating a subsystem in an isolated configuration to ensure that it meets the behaviors allocated to it in a system design. The process of interface control document validation in the illustrative examples tests a subsystem-unique interface control document. The subsystem interface control document describes the details of the data crossing the interface(s), and allocates functions to each subsystem within the design. The illustrative examples are configured to perform interface control document validation to exercise each aspect of the subsystem's interface individually in accordance with the system-unique interface control document.

(16) Turning now to FIG. **1**, an illustration of a block diagram of a testing environment is depicted in which an illustrative embodiment may be implemented. An interface control document of subsystem **100** is validated in testing environment **102**. Subsystem **100** will desirably be used in system **104**. Subsystem **100** is one of subsystems **103** of system **104**. In some illustrative examples, system **104** is being designed and subsystem **100** is a desired part for system **104**. In some illustrative examples, system **104** has been designed and subsystem **100** is an aftermarket part. In some illustrative examples, system **104** takes the form of aircraft **105**.

(17) Although the illustrative examples are described with respect to an aircraft, an illustrative embodiment may be applied to other types of platforms. The platform may be, for example, a mobile platform, a stationary platform, a land-based structure, an aquatic-based structure, or a space-based structure. More specifically, the platform may be a surface ship, a tank, a personnel carrier, a train, a spacecraft, a space station, a satellite, a submarine, an automobile, a power plant, a bridge, a dam, a house, a manufacturing facility, a building, and other suitable platforms.

(18) Subsystem **100** is physically connected to test rig **106**. Test rig **106** is a mechanical rig that provides physical connections to subsystem **100**. In some illustrative examples, the physical connections in test rig **106** comprise at least one of utility connections or mechanical restraint. Utility connections can include at least one of electrical wiring, pneumatic connections, hydraulic connections, a water source, a vacuum source, or any other desirable utility connection.

(19) Virtual software environment **108** is present in computer system **110**. Virtual software environment **108** creates a communication connection to subsystem **100**. In some illustrative examples, the communication connection is wireless. In some illustrative examples, the communication connection between virtual software environment **108** and subsystem **100** is formed of wires independent of test rig **106**. In some illustrative examples, connecting wires from test rig **106** to virtual software environment **108** creates a communication connection to subsystem **100**. Virtual software environment **108** provides subsystem input **112** to validate the interface control document of subsystem **100**. Virtual software environment **108** receives subsystem output **114** to validate the interface control document of subsystem **100**.

(20) In some illustrative examples, the physical connections of test rig **106** are configured based on specifications **116** for system **104**. In some illustrative examples, specifications **116** are part of a preliminary design for system **104**. In some illustrative examples, specifications **116** are for system **104** that has been assembled. Virtual software environment **108** provides subsystem input **112** configured to mimic operating conditions of system **104**. The digital interface between subsystem **100** and computer system **110** could be MIL-STD-1553 wiring, ARINC-429 wiring, or ethernet wiring. Virtual software environment **108** is configured to adapt to any of these interfaces.

(21) Virtual software environment **108** emulates algorithms and logic planned for one of subsystems **103** that will interface with subsystem **100**, before design for system **104** has begun, and serves to digitally stimulate subsystem **100**. In these illustrative examples, virtual software environment **108** is configured to emulate software logic and algorithms that have not yet been coded. Virtual software environment **108** is a software package that provides a graphical user interface for an operator to use to control virtual software environment **108** to assess behavior of subsystem **100**.

(22) Test rig **106** is configured to mimic operating conditions of system **104**. In some illustrative examples, the mechanical rig, test rig **106**, holds subsystem **100**. Depending on the details of subsystem **100**, test rig **106** can also emulate other aspects of system **104**. In some illustrative examples, test rig **106** emulates electrical signal inputs to subsystem **100**, such as discrete (i.e., switches) or analog signals. In some illustrative examples, test rig **106** generates Radio Frequency (RF) energy from a radio transmitter. In some illustrative examples, test rig **106** includes thermal management provisions, such as fans. In some illustrative examples, test rig **106** includes components to simulate motion. In some illustrative examples, system **104** is aircraft **105** and test rig **106** includes components to emulate aircraft pitch and roll.

(23) In some illustrative examples, test rig **106** provides stimulation to introduce undesirable conditions into subsystem **100**. In some illustrative examples, test rig **106** comprises stimulation to introduce opens or shorts to subsystem **100**. In some illustrative examples, test rig **106** comprises stimulation to introduce overheating to subsystem **100**.

(24) In some illustrative examples, external non-digital stimulator **118** provides external forces acting upon subsystem **100**. In some illustrative examples, external non-digital stimulator **118** is provided to mimic operating conditions of system **104**. In some illustrative examples, external non-digital stimulator **118** is provided to test the interface control document of subsystem **100**.

(25) In some illustrative examples, external non-digital stimulator **118** is optional. In some illustrative examples, virtual software environment **108** sends stimulation to subsystem **100**, wherein the stimulation emulates input for subsystem **100** from a physical piece of equipment.

(26) In some illustrative examples, virtual software environment **108** is configured to provide emulation of at least one of electrical, mechanical, kinetic, digital, and thermodynamic inputs from a component of system **104** or commands from a component of system **104**. In some illustrative examples, virtual software environment **108** emulates stimulation for a sensor of subsystem **100**. In these illustrative examples, external non-digital stimulator **118** is optional.

(27) FIG. 1 shows a simplified block diagram of a virtual software environment and subsystem interface control document validation setup. The illustration of testing environment **102** in FIG. 1 is

not meant to imply physical or architectural limitations to the manner in which an illustrative embodiment may be implemented. Other components in addition to or in place of the ones illustrated may be used. Some components may be unnecessary. Also, the blocks are presented to illustrate some functional components. One or more of these blocks may be combined, divided, or combined and divided into different blocks when implemented in an illustrative embodiment. (28) For example, a display (not depicted) can be connected to virtual software environment **108**. In these illustrative examples, virtual software environment **108** can display commands for and results from testing subsystem **100**.

(29) Turning now to FIG. **2**, an illustration of a block diagram of a testing environment is depicted in which an illustrative embodiment may be implemented. Testing environment **200** includes testing system **202** to test subsystem **204**. In some illustrative examples, testing environment **200** is the same as testing environment **102** of FIG. **2**.

(30) Testing system **202** in testing environment **200** is configured to test subsystem **204** prior to assembly into system **206**. More specifically, testing system **202** in testing environment **200** is configured to test interfaces **203** of subsystem **204** prior to assembly into system **206**. Testing system **202** comprises physical and software components. Testing system **202** comprises physical and software components to emulate at least one of electrical, mechanical, kinetic, digital, and thermodynamic inputs for subsystem **204**.

(31) Testing system **202** comprises test rig **208** and virtual software environment **210**. Test rig **208** comprises electrical wiring **212** and mechanical restraint **214** configured to emulate at least one of physical specifications **209** of system **206**. Virtual software environment **210** is developed to emulate operating software **216** and/or hardware for system **206** in software emulation **224** and/or hardware emulation **226**.

(32) Operating software **216** is one of subsystems **217** of system **206**. Subsystem **204** is a physical implementation of one of subsystems **217** to be used in system **206**.

(33) Virtual software environment **210** emulates algorithms and logic planned for a subsystem of subsystems **217** that will interface with subsystem **204**, before design of system **206** has begun, and serves to digitally stimulate subsystem **204**. Virtual software environment **210** is a software package that provides a graphical user interface for an operator to use to control virtual software environment **210** in order to assess behavior of subsystem **204**. Virtual software environment **210** is a software package that allows for testing of subsystem **204** with the interfacing algorithms and logic intended to be developed for operating software **216**.

(34) In some illustrative examples, test rig **208** is an implementation of test rig **106** of FIG. **1**. In some illustrative examples, virtual software environment **210** is an implementation of virtual software environment **108** of FIG. **1**.

(35) Power source **218** provides power to electrical wiring **212** of test rig **208**. Test rig **208** is a mechanical rig. Test rig **208** is configured to emulate at least one of physical specifications **209** of system **206**. In some illustrative examples, physical specifications **209** comprises at least one of dimensions within system **206** for subsystem **204**, types of electrical connections, types of electrical wiring, voltage and current of provided power, an operating temperature, movement of system **206**, or other utilities.

(36) To test interfaces **203** of subsystem **204**, electrical wiring **212** of test rig **208** is connected to electrical interface **220** of subsystem **204**. In some illustrative examples, electrical wiring **212** is designed as the electrical wiring in specifications **221** of system **206**. For example, electrical wiring **212** can include the same quantity, size, and design as electrical wiring in specifications **221** of system **206**. To test interfaces **203** of subsystem **204**, mechanical restraint **214** of test rig **208** is connected to mechanical interface **222** of subsystem **204**.

(37) Operating software **216** is the software that will be in use in system **206** during operation of system **206**. Operating software **216** is designed for system **206**. In some illustrative examples, operating software **216** has not yet been programmed. In these illustrative examples, virtual

software environment **210** is configured to emulate software logic and algorithms that have not yet been coded.

(38) Virtual software environment **210** provides software emulation **224** of operating software **216** and hardware emulation **226**. Hardware emulation may emulate input for subsystem **204** from a physical piece of equipment planned for subsystems **217**. Virtual software environment **210** is a package of tools developed to model the operating software **216** that will be developed later, during the build phase of the program. The models of virtual software environment **210** are used to emulate the timing, interface data structures, control algorithms, data processing, and display capabilities of the planned software, operating software **216**. Virtual software environment **210** allows any of these aspects of the emulated operating system to be rapidly modified when a design change is identified by the testing of subsystem **204**.

(39) Testing of subsystem **204** comprises validation of interface control document **228** for subsystem **204**. In some illustrative examples, testing subsystem **204** is called interface control document validation. Interface control document **228** describes the inputs and outputs of subsystem **204**. Interface control document **228** includes at least one of electrical **230**, mechanical **232**, or software **234** inputs and outputs.

(40) In some illustrative examples, test rig **208** further comprises kinetic components **236** configured to generate movement of test rig **208** and subsystem **204**. In some illustrative examples, kinetic components **236** are configured to provide input to validate operation of subsystem **204**. For example, if subsystem **204** is a system to measure or detect motion, kinetic components **236** provide input to subsystem **204**.

(41) In some illustrative examples, test rig **208** comprises kinetic components **236** configured to emulate motions of system **206** while system **206** is in operation. For example, kinetic components **236** can generate motion of test rig **208** to verify operation of subsystem **204** with expected motions of system **206** during operation. In some illustrative examples, system **206** takes the form of aircraft **272**. In some illustrative examples, kinetic components **236** are configured to generate motions to emulate operations of aircraft **272**.

(42) In some illustrative examples, test rig **208** further comprises thermodynamic components **238**. In some illustrative examples, thermodynamic components **238** are configured to emulate operational thermodynamic conditions of system **206**. In some illustrative examples, test rig **208** further comprises thermodynamic components **238** configured to provide thermal management of subsystem **204**. In some illustrative examples, thermodynamic components **238** provide air flow **240** to provide thermal management of subsystem **204**. In some illustrative examples, thermodynamic components **238** provide at least one of heating **241** or cooling **242** to emulate operational thermodynamic conditions of system **206**. In some illustrative examples, thermodynamic components **238** provide at least one of heating **241** or cooling **242** to provide thermal management of subsystem **204**.

(43) Subsystem **204** comprises communication interface **244**. Subsystem **204** communicates with virtual software environment **210** via communication interface **244**. Communication interface **244** takes any desirable form, such as high speed ethernet, wireless, military standard databus, or commercial serial.

(44) In some illustrative examples, subsystem **204** has sensor **246**. Sensor **246** is configured to detect any desirable type of input. In some illustrative examples, external non-digital stimulator **248** is provided to stimulate sensor **246**. In some illustrative examples, external non-digital stimulator **248** is provided to test operation of subsystem **204** when non-digital stimulation is present. In some illustrative examples, external non-digital stimulator **248** is configured to generate one of RF energy **250** or heat energy **252**. In some illustrative examples, external non-digital stimulator **248** is provided to emulate operational parameters of system **206**. In some illustrative examples, external non-digital stimulator **248** is configured to generate a stimulus for subsystem **204**. In some illustrative examples, external non-digital stimulator **248** generates at least one of

radio frequency (RF) energy **250**, heat energy **252**, light **254**, or x-rays **256**.

(45) In some illustrative examples, virtual software environment **210** is further configured to provide emulation of at least one of data from a component of system **206** or commands from a component of system **206**. In some illustrative examples, virtual software environment **210** emulates stimulation for sensor **246**. In these illustrative examples, external non-digital stimulator **248** is optional. In another illustrative example, virtual software environment **210** sends input to communication interface **244** that emulates input from a component of aircraft **272**. In some illustrative examples, virtual software environment **210** sends stimulation to subsystem **204** wherein the stimulation emulates input for subsystem **204** from a physical piece of equipment.

(46) As depicted, virtual software environment **210** is present in computer system **258**. As virtual software environment **210** performs tests on subsystem **204**, virtual software environment **210** creates data recording **260** of results. Data recording **260** enables operators to review results after testing of subsystem **204**. As virtual software environment **210** performs tests on subsystem **204**, virtual software environment **210** displays inputs and outputs for subsystem **204** on display **262** in real time. During testing of subsystem **204**, operators can view inputs and outputs for subsystem **204** on display **262** to review results of testing using virtual software environment **210**.

(47) In some illustrative examples, video camera **264** is present in testing system **202**. Video camera **264** is configured to record results of testing subsystem **204**. In some illustrative examples, video camera **264** is directed towards subsystem **204** within testing system **202**. In some illustrative examples, video camera **264** is directed towards display **262** and subsystem **204** within testing system **202**. Video camera **264** generates video recording **266** during testing of subsystem **204**. Video recording **266** can be reviewed after testing to observe behavior of subsystem **204** during testing.

(48) For an interface control document validation test, expected results are developed from interface control documents **228** supplied with subsystem **204**. The expected results allow validation of the behaviors of subsystem **204** within testing system **202**. When inconsistencies are discovered, changes can be made to at least one of specifications **221** of system **206**, software logic and algorithms in software emulation **224**, or interface control documents **228**. In some illustrative examples, modifications are incorporated into interface control documents **228** to form revised interface control documents **270** based on the inconsistency.

(49) Each aspect of interface control documents **228** is tested by testing subsystem **204**. In some illustrative examples, testing of subsystem **204** is performed one interface at a time. A number of examples of tests to be performed on subsystem **204** is provided below:

(50) In one example, subsystem **204** is tested for initialization time. In one example, subsystem **204** is expected to complete initialization within N seconds. In this example, N is a placeholder for a set value within interface control documents **228**. In this example, virtual software environment **210** will monitor outputs of subsystem **204** received from an interface between subsystem **204** and virtual software environment **210** for an output that indicates “initialization complete” and provides the measured initialization time.

(51) In some illustrative examples, if subsystem **204** exceeds the initialization time provided in interface control documents **228**, specifications **221** of system **206** are modified. In some illustrative examples, a subsystem control model of virtual software environment **210** will be rapidly adjusted to test subsystem **204** with this updated expectation. In some illustrative examples, the planned system behaviors of operating software **216** will be updated to reflect this new understanding of the initialization time of subsystem **204**, prior to software coding of operating software **216**. In some illustrative examples, interface control documents **228** are modified to form revised interface control documents **270** with the updated initialization time of subsystem **204**.

(52) In another example, subsystem **204** is tested for current draw. In one example, subsystem **204** is expected to draw a maximum of N Amps of DC current.

(53) As the virtual software environment **210** controls all the modes and events available with

subsystem **204**, a current monitor is used to measure the power draw for subsystem **204**. If subsystem **204** exceeds the maximum power draw specified in interface control documents **228**, then a modification is made to electrical **230** interface control document, and the electrical system specifications for aircraft **272** are modified to accommodate the actual behavior of subsystem **204**. In some illustrative examples, a wiring design for system **206** in specifications **221** is adjusted to ensure that an electrical circuit breaker for subsystem **204** in system **206** is properly sized. In some illustrative examples, the measured power draw is used in the design of the electrical system of system **206** to ensure that system **206** can provide the power required by subsystem **204**.

(54) For an interface control document validation test, expected results are developed from interface control documents **228** for subsystem **204**. The following are examples of expected results for subsystem **204**.

(55) In one example, subsystem **204** is expected to change from Mode A to Mode B when data bit C is set to 1 using communication interface **244**. Virtual software environment **210** will command subsystem **204** to Mode B by setting data bit C, in accordance with interface control documents **228**. If a subsystem monitor model of virtual software environment **210** displays that subsystem **204** has failed to transition to Mode B with the specified command, an investigation will be performed.

(56) If the investigation reveals that Mode B requires both data bits C AND D to be set to 1, then a subsystem control model of virtual software environment **210** will be adjusted to test this. The planned system behaviors of operating software **216** will be updated to reflect this new understanding, prior to software coding.

(57) In some illustrative examples, system **206** takes the form of aircraft **272**. Aircraft **272** is a complex system. By modifying specifications **221** prior to building aircraft **272**, significant manufacturing time and resources can be saved. By modifying operating software **216** based on unexpected results of interface control document validation, significant programming time can be saved.

(58) Validating interface control documents **228** using test rig **208** and virtual software environment **210** can improve technical quality. Validating interface control documents **228** using test rig **208** and virtual software environment **210** leads to cost savings and schedule gains.

(59) Turning now to FIG. 3, an illustration of a block diagram of a data flow of a virtual software environment is depicted in accordance with an illustrative embodiment. Data flow **300** can be implemented in virtual software environment **108** of FIG. 1 or virtual software environment **210** of FIG. 2. Data flow **300** demonstrates movement of data between virtual software environment (VSE) **302** and subsystem **304**.

(60) Digital data bus **306** provides data flow **310** from virtual software environment **302** to subsystem **304**. Digital data bus **308** sends data flow **312** from subsystem **304** to virtual software environment **302**.

(61) Virtual software environment **302** comprises several layers. Data flow **312** from subsystem **304** travels through an Application Programming Interface (API) to physical layer interface **314**, data conversion software **316**, subsystem monitor model **320**, and user interface **322**. Data flow **310** from virtual software environment **302** travels from user interface **322**, subsystem control model **318**, data conversion software **316**, and API to physical layer interface **314** prior to reaching digital data bus **306**.

(62) User Interface **322** provides a graphical interface for an operator to interact with virtual software environment **302**. User interface **322** provides the ability to enter commands, and to view data from subsystem **304**. Virtual software environment **302** provides a generalized software platform that can be tailored to meet the needs of any specific subsystem.

(63) Subsystem Control Model **318** is a software model of the behaviors planned for the operating software of the system to control the subsystem. As behaviors are designed during the preliminary design, they are modeled in Subsystem Control Model **318**. Virtual software environment **302**

provides a generalized software platform that can be tailored to meet the needs of any specific subsystem.

(64) Subsystem Monitor Model **320** is a software model of the behaviors planned for the software of the system that will monitor and provide status for subsystem **304**. Subsystem Monitor Model **320** receives command and status data from digital data bus **308** (via Data Conversion Software **316**) and provides that data to User Interface **322**. Virtual software environment **302** provides a generalized software platform that can be tailored to meet the needs of any specific subsystem.

(65) Data Conversion Software **316** is an interfacing software package that converts commands and status between the digital format used by the digital data bus protocol of subsystem **304** and a protocol-independent data structure used by the subsystem models. A unique Data Conversion Software package is customized for each different type of digital data bus protocol (e.g., MIL-STD-1553, ARINC-429, ethernet). Data Conversion Software **316** uses a subsystem-specific Data Dictionary that maps subsystem model data elements into protocol-specific data elements. The Data Dictionary is modified for each subsystem to allow the Data Conversion Software to remain static across subsystems that use the same protocol. This feature supports the rapid build-up of the virtual software environment **302** for new subsystems.

(66) API to Physical Layer Interface **314** is a hardware/software system that outputs and receives the electrical signals specific to the digital data bus protocol of subsystem **304**. In some illustrative examples, API to physical layer interface **314** is purchased and then integrated with custom Data Conversion Software **316**.

(67) In some illustrative examples, the virtual software environment is developed using software that allows non-software professionals to develop emulation logic and algorithms efficiently, and supports rapid change during interface control document validation. The virtual software environment includes a variety of tools that support efficient customization for different subsystem designs. Interfaces that can be utilized in the virtual software environment include MIL-STD-1553, ARINC-429, and ethernet. The virtual software environment can be easily modified to utilize different interface timing and processing rates to accurately emulate the planned system behavior. As an added benefit, this element of the virtual software environment can be utilized later, when the full system is brought together for testing.

(68) Turning now to FIG. **4**, an illustration of a testing environment is depicted in accordance with an illustrative embodiment. Testing environment **400** is a physical implementation of testing environment **102** of FIG. **1** or testing environment **200** of FIG. **2**. In testing environment **400**, subsystem **402** is resting on test rig **404**. Test rig **404** includes utility connections **406**. Plurality of wires **408** connect subsystem **402** to test rig **404**. Plurality of wires **408** provide utilities from test rig **404** to subsystem **402**. In some illustrative examples, connecting plurality of wires **408** from test rig **404** to virtual software environment **410** creates a communication connection between subsystem **402** and the virtual software environment **410**. In some other illustrative examples, a wireless connection forms a communication connection between subsystem **402** and virtual software environment **410**.

(69) Virtual software environment **410** is present within computer **412**. Virtual software environment **410** is connected to subsystem **402** by plurality of wires **408**.

(70) In testing environment **400**, virtual software environment **410** provides data to display **414**. An operator can provide input to virtual software environment **410** using graphical user interface **416**. An operator can provide input to virtual software environment **410** using one of mouse **418** or keyboard **420**. In other illustrative examples, user input can be received through another type of input device, such as a touch screen.

(71) Although not depicted in FIG. **4**, a video camera can be present in testing environment **400**. In some illustrative examples, a video camera is configured to record results of testing subsystem **402**. In some illustrative examples, a video camera is directed to record subsystem **402**. In some illustrative examples, a video camera is directed to record display **414** and subsystem **402**.

(72) Although not depicted in FIG. 4, an external non-digital stimulator can be present in testing environment **400**. In some illustrative examples, an external non-digital stimulator is configured to generate a stimulus for subsystem **402**.

(73) Turning now to FIGS. 5A and 5B, a flowchart of a method of validating an interface control document of a subsystem is depicted in accordance with an illustrative embodiment. Method **500** can be used to validate an interface control document of subsystem **100** of FIG. 1. Method **500** can be used to validate an interface control document of subsystem **204** of FIG. 2. Method **500** can be implemented using virtual software environment **302** of FIG. 3. Method **500** can be used to validate an interface control document of subsystem **402** of FIG. 4.

(74) FIGS. 5A and 5B provide a flowchart for an illustrative example of an Interface Control Document validation test. Method **500** uses a virtual software environment, such as virtual software environment **108** of FIG. 1 or virtual software environment **210** of FIG. 2, to initialize the subsystem and command the subsystem. The subsystem and virtual software environment are powered on in operation **502**. The virtual software environment begins initialization command sequence in operation **504**.

(75) The subsystem receives the commands and reacts to the virtual software environment with status data in operation **506**. The virtual software environment graphically depicts the command and the status digital data in operation **508**. In some illustrative examples, the graphical displays are tailored to support validation of the subsystem's behavior against the subsystem interface control document.

(76) In some illustrative examples, the virtual software environment provides real-time graphical data on a large monitor that can be viewed by multiple engineers in a collaborative environment. In some illustrative examples, real-time data is displayed with graphics, allowing engineers to collaboratively assess the system behaviors in-real-time and adjust the test, if desired. In some illustrative examples, data is recorded in operation **510** to be analyzed post-test.

(77) Method **500** confirms the subsystem initialization matches the expectation in operation **512**. To determine if the subsystem initialization is as expected, method **500** utilizes the subsystem interface control documents **514**. Method **500** produces test results **516** from determining if the initialization matches the expectation.

(78) Operation **502** through operation **516** are for an initialization test of the subsystem. System initialization is the process of starting the subsystem from a powered-off condition and allowing the subsystem to progress through its startup sequence. Each subsystem has a specified amount of time to complete initialization. Subsystem initialization timing is a significant interface characteristic that is tested during interface control document validation.

(79) After performing the initialization test, the operation of the subsystem is then tested in operation **518** through operation **544**. Operation tests for the subsystem are performed based on a subsystem type, subsystem inputs, subsystem outputs, and operational conditions of the system and the subsystem.

(80) In order to test other results of the subsystem against the interface control document, control input **517** is provided to generate commands to the subsystem in operation **518**. In some illustrative examples, control input **517** is generated by an operator. In some illustrative examples, control input **517** is generated by an algorithm or computer program. In operation **518** the virtual software environment generates the commands to the subsystem. In some illustrative examples, the subsystem is also stimulated with external inputs in operation **520** as the commands are sent to the subsystem. In some illustrative examples, an external non-digital stimulator is configured to generate a stimulus for the subsystem. External inputs can include at least one of mechanical input, test set input, RF energy, motion, heat, or any other type of external input. In some of these illustrative examples, each of these external inputs can be considered a stimulus. In some illustrative examples, the virtual software environment emulates external inputs to stimulate the subsystem.

(81) The virtual software environment displays the command and status data in operation **522**. The virtual software environment displays the status data in operation **524**. In some illustrative examples, the status data is displayed on a large screen within the testing environment for real-time analysis and data review by a team of collaborating engineers. The virtual software environment records data in operation **526**. The recorded data can be reviewed later for the status of the subsystem in response to the commands.

(82) The interface control documents (ICDs) specific to the subsystem are provided in operation **528**. A determination made in operation **530** confirms whether the subsystem response matches an expectation based on the interface control documents. Test results are generated in operation **532**. In some illustrative examples, the virtual software environment records the output of the subsystem in data storage.

(83) In operation **534** it is determined if all testing of the subsystem has been completed. If additional testing is remaining, method **500** returns to position A to repeat operation **517** through operation **534**. Operation **517** through operation **534** are repeated iteratively until all desired tests are run on the subsystem.

(84) If all testing has been completed at operation **534**, method **500** moves to operation **540**. To perform operation **540**, test results are provided in operation **536** and recorded data is provided in operation **538**. Using the test results and the recorded data, if the subsystem behavior is inconsistent with the interface control documents for the subsystem, the interface control document is updated in operation **540**. Revised subsystem interface control documents are generated in operation **542**. Afterwards, method **500** terminates in operation **544**.

(85) Turning now to FIG. **6**, a flowchart of operating a virtual software environment is depicted in accordance with an illustrative embodiment. Method **600** can be used to operate virtual software environment **108** of FIG. **1** in validating an interface control document of subsystem **100**. Method **600** can be performed by virtual software environment **210** of FIG. **2** to validate an interface control document of subsystem **204** of FIG. **2**. Method **600** can be implemented using virtual software environment **302** of FIG. **3**. Method **600** can be used by virtual software environment **410** to validate an interface control document of subsystem **402** of FIG. **4**.

(86) Operation **602** through operation **614** involve testing the subsystem initialization. Subsystem initialization is the process of starting the subsystem from a powered-off condition and allowing the subsystem to progress through its startup sequence. Each subsystem has a specified amount of time to complete initialization. Subsystem initialization timing is a significant interface characteristic that is tested during Interface Control Document validation.

(87) Most subsystems perform a startup test during initialization, and then report the results to the operating software, which is represented by the Virtual Software Environment during Interface Control Document validation. The subsystem's startup test behaviors and reported results are evaluated during interface control document validation.

(88) Often, subsystems utilize a sequenced digital handshake with the operating software to complete the startup sequence. These sequenced handshakes are thoroughly tested during interface control document validation to ensure that the subsystem behaviors and the behaviors required of the operating software are well understood. An example of a digital handshake during subsystem startup includes power applied signal from system power, startup test in progress from subsystem, startup test status from subsystem, installation configuration command from operating software, acknowledge configuration command from subsystem, and ready to accept commands from subsystem.

(89) In operation **602** the virtual software environment initiates periodic messaging with the subsystem. In operation **604** the virtual software environment sends a command initialization to the subsystem and records data in operation **606**. The data recorded in operation **606** includes the command sent to the subsystem. In operation **608** the virtual software environment receives status data from the subsystem after initialization. The virtual software environment records the data at

operation **610**. The data includes the status data output from the subsystem.

(90) In operation **612** the timing and status of initialization is computed. The test results from the timing and status of initialization are displayed in operation **614**.

(91) Operations **602-614** tests the initialization of the subsystem. Afterwards, the virtual software environment waits for control input to be provided to test the subsystem. In operations **620-644**, the virtual software environment performs testing of a subsystem to validate the interface control documents of the subsystem. The control input can test each aspect of the interface control documents for the subsystem individually. Testing of the subsystem can include testing operating conditions of the subsystem. In some illustrative examples, testing can include injecting faults with the test rig to evaluate subsystem behaviors.

(92) Control input is provided in **616**. After the virtual software environment determines a command is received at operation **618**, the virtual software environment validates the command and sends the control data to the subsystem in operation **620**

(93) The virtual software environment receives command data over a data bus in operation **622**. The data is recorded for the received command data in operation **624**. The command data is converted to graphical user interface (GUI) elements in operation **626**. The command data is displayed to an operator in operation **628**.

(94) Status data is received from the subsystem in response to the command in operation **630**. The status data is recorded by the virtual software environment in operation **632**. In operation **634**, the virtual software environment determines if there is an inconsistency in the status data received from the subsystem. An inconsistency is present in the status data when the status data deviates from an expected result based on the interface control documents of the subsystem.

(95) If an inconsistency is detected at operation **634**, an operator is notified in operation **636**. The inconsistency is displayed to the operator in operation **638**. In some illustrative examples, the operator is notified in operation **636** by displaying a notification in the graphical user interface of the virtual software environment. In some illustrative examples, the inconsistency is displayed in operation **638** by displaying the status data and the expected outcome in the graphical user interface of the virtual software environment. After the inconsistency is displayed to an operator, method **600** returns to operation **618** to await control input **616** to test additional aspects of the interface control documents of the subsystem.

(96) If an inconsistency is not present in operation **634**, the status data is converted to graphical user interface (GUI) elements operation **640**. In operation **642** the status data is displayed to an operator. After the status data is displayed to an operator, method **600** returns to operation **618** to await control input **616** to test additional aspects of the interface control documents of the subsystem.

(97) Turning now to FIG. 7, a flowchart of a method of testing a subsystem is depicted in accordance with an illustrative embodiment. Method **700** can be performed using test rig **106** and virtual software environment **108** of FIG. 1. Method **700** can be performed using testing system **202** of FIG. 2. Method **700** can be performed using virtual software environment **302** of FIG. 3. Method **700** can be performed using test rig **404** and virtual software environment **410** of FIG. 4.

(98) Method **700** receives input at a virtual software environment to generate a command for the subsystem (operation **702**). Method **700** responsively generates, via the virtual software environment, a command to send to the subsystem (operation **704**). Method **700** receives output from the subsystem (operation **706**). Method **700** determines if there is an inconsistency between the output from the subsystem and interface control documents of the subsystem (operation **708**). Afterwards, method **700** terminates.

(99) In some illustrative examples, method **700** connects wires from a test rig configured to emulate at least one physical specification of a system to the virtual software environment, wherein connecting the wires from the test rig to the virtual software environment creates a communication connection to the subsystem (operation **710**). In some illustrative examples, method **700** sends the

command to the subsystem via wiring connecting the virtual software environment to the subsystem (operation **712**). In some illustrative examples, method **700** sends stimulation to the subsystem from the virtual software environment, wherein the stimulation emulates input for the subsystem from a physical piece of equipment (operation **714**). In some illustrative examples, method **700** displays the output to an operator (operation **716**). In some illustrative examples, method **700** records the output of the subsystem in data storage (operation **718**).

(100) In some illustrative examples, method **700** reports a detected inconsistency (operation **720**). In some illustrative examples, method **700** incorporates modifications into the interface control document to form revised subsystem interface control documents based on the inconsistency (operation **722**).

(101) Turning now to FIG. **8**, a flowchart of a method of testing a subsystem prior to installation in a system is depicted in accordance with an illustrative embodiment. Method **800** can be performed using test rig **106** and virtual software environment **108** of FIG. **1**. Method **800** can be performed using testing system **202** of FIG. **2**. Method **800** can be performed using virtual software environment **302** of FIG. **3**. Method **800** can be performed using test rig **404** and virtual software environment **410** of FIG. **4**.

(102) Method **800** receives an interface control document for the subsystem (operation **802**). Method **800** positions the subsystem onto a test rig configured to provide mechanical emulation of the system (operation **804**). Method **800** performs validation of an interface control document for the subsystem using the test rig and a virtual software environment developed to emulate software for the system (operation **806**). Afterward, method **800** terminates.

(103) In some illustrative examples, method **800** further comprises restraining the subsystem on the test rig by connecting a mechanical restraint of the test rig to a mechanical interface of the subsystem (operation **808**). The mechanical restraint can take any desirable form. In some illustrative examples, the mechanical restraint comprises a number of fasteners.

(104) In some illustrative examples, performing validation of the interface control document of method **800** comprises sending commands to the subsystem (operation **810**). In some illustrative examples, performing validation of the interface control document of method **800** further comprises evaluating output of the subsystem generated in response to the commands (operation **812**).

(105) In some illustrative examples, performing validation of the interface control document of method **800** comprises providing external stimulation to the subsystem (operation **814**). In some illustrative examples, providing external stimulation to the subsystem comprises one of: generating one of RF energy or heat energy, generating movement of the test rig and subsystem, applying radio waves, or generating an airflow (operation **816**).

(106) In some illustrative examples, performing validation of the interface control document of method **800** further comprises determining modifications to the interface control document when the output of the subsystem is inconsistent with the interface control document for the subsystem (operation **818**). In some illustrative examples, method **800** incorporates the modifications into the interface control document to form revised subsystem interface control documents.

(107) As used herein, the phrase “at least one of,” when used with a list of items, means different combinations of one or more of the listed items may be used and only one of each item in the list may be needed. For example, “at least one of item A, item B, or item C” may include, without limitation, item A, item A and item B, or item B. This example also may include item A, item B, and item C or item B and item C. Of course, any combinations of these items may be present. In other examples, “at least one of” may be, for example, without limitation, two of item A; one of item B; and ten of item C; four of item B and seven of item C; or other suitable combinations. The item may be a particular object, thing, or a category. In other words, at least one of means any combination items and number of items may be used from the list but not all of the items in the list are required.

(108) The flowcharts and block diagrams in the different depicted embodiments illustrate the architecture, functionality, and operation of some possible implementations of apparatuses and methods in an illustrative embodiment. In this regard, each block in the flowcharts or block diagrams may represent at least one of a module, a segment, a function, or a portion of an operation or step.

(109) In some alternative implementations of an illustrative embodiment, the function or functions noted in the blocks may occur out of the order noted in the figures. For example, in some cases, two blocks shown in succession may be executed substantially concurrently, or the blocks may sometimes be performed in the reverse order, depending upon the functionality involved. Also, other blocks may be added in addition to the illustrated blocks in a flowchart or block diagram. Some blocks may be optional. For example, any of operation **710** through operation **722** may be optional. As another example, any of operation **808** through operation **820** may be optional. As another example, any of operation **1012** through operation **1024** of FIG. **10** may be optional.

(110) Turning now to FIG. **9**, an illustration of a systems design flow with interface control document validation is depicted in accordance with an illustrative embodiment. Test rig **106** and virtual software environment **108** of FIG. **1** enable interface control document validation within design flow **900**. Testing system **202** of FIG. **2** enables interface control document validation within design flow **900**. Virtual software environment **302** of FIG. **3** enables interface control document validation within design flow **900**. Test rig **404** and virtual software environment **410** of FIG. **4** can perform interface control document validation within design flow **900**. Method **500** of FIG. **5** can be used to validate an interface control document in design flow **900**. Method **600** of FIG. **6** can be used to validate an interface control document in design flow **900**.

(111) In design flow **900**, system specifications **902** are set. The system specifications **902** can be set based on customer requests, performance goals, and regulatory conditions. After setting system specifications **902**, subsystem specifications **904** are generated. In conventional design processes, the design would continue through preliminary design **906**, detailed design **908**, and build **910** of the components and subcomponents of the system. In conventional design processes, validation of interface control documents of a subsystem is performed in testing and qualification **914** after integration **912**. In conventional design processes, validation of interface control documents can introduce undesirable delays for inconsistencies between the behavior of the subsystem and the interface control documents for the subsystem.

(112) In design flow **900**, interface control document (ICD) validation **920** can be performed after subsystem specifications **904**. In some illustrative examples, in design flow **900**, interface control document (ICD) validation **920** can be performed after preliminary design **906**. By performing interface control document validation **920** prior to detailed design **908**, design time can be reduced. By performing interface control document validation **920** prior to detailed design **908**, design can be reduced by reducing redesign due to interface control document inconsistencies. By performing interface control document validation **920** prior to detailed design **908**, interface control document validation **920** can improve technical quality, leading to cost savings and schedule gains.

(113) In some illustrative examples, in design flow **900**, interface control document (ICD) validation **922** can be performed after system delivery **916**. In some illustrative examples, in design flow **900**, interface control document (ICD) validation **922** can be performed after operation **918**. In some illustrative examples, interface control document (ICD) validation **922** is performed for an after-market component for the system. In some illustrative examples, interface control document (ICD) validation **922** is performed for a replacement component for the system. By providing emulation of subsystems of the system, interface control document validation **922** can reduce downtime of the system. For example, the system can remain in operation **918** while the interfaces of the subsystem are tested.

(114) Turning now to FIG. **10** is a flowchart of a method of testing a subsystem prior to installation in a system is depicted in accordance with an illustrative embodiment. Method **1000** can be

performed using test rig **106** and virtual software environment **108** of FIG. 1. Method **1000** can be performed using testing system **202** of FIG. 2. Method **1000** can be performed using virtual software environment **302** of FIG. 3. Method **1000** can be performed using test rig **404** and virtual software environment **410** of FIG. 4.

(115) Method **1000** receives specifications for the system (operation **1002**). Method **1000** develops specifications for subassemblies of the system from the specifications of the system (operation **1004**). Method **1000** performs validation of an interface control document of a subsystem to be used in the system to determine modifications to one of the interface control document or a design for the system (operation **1006**). Method **1000** incorporates the modifications into at least one of the interface control document or a design for the system (operation **1008**). Afterwards, method **1000** terminates.

(116) In some illustrative examples, method **1000** builds the system according to the design of the system (operation **1010**). In some illustrative examples, performing validation of interface control document of a subsystem to be used in the system comprises emulating hardware and software of the system using a test rig and a virtual software environment (operation **1012**).

(117) In some illustrative examples, the virtual software environment emulates software for the system and simulates outside inputs to the subsystem (operation **1014**). In some illustrative examples, the virtual software environment emulates software for the system and simulates electrical wiring of the system (operation **1016**). In some illustrative examples, performing validation of interface control document of a subsystem comprises the virtual software environment graphically depicting a command to the subsystem and status data of the subsystem (operation **1018**).

(118) In some illustrative examples, the modifications comprise changes to physical elements of the system (operation **1020**). In some illustrative examples, the modifications comprise changes to utilities of the system (operation **1022**). In some illustrative examples, the modifications comprise changes to software of the system (operation **1024**).

(119) Illustrative embodiments of the present disclosure may be described in the context of aircraft manufacturing and service method **1100** as shown in FIG. **11** and aircraft **1200** as shown in FIG. **12**. Turning first to FIG. **11**, an illustration of an aircraft manufacturing and service method is depicted in accordance with an illustrative embodiment. During pre-production, aircraft manufacturing and service method **1100** may include specification and design **1102** of aircraft **1200** in FIG. **12** and material procurement **1104**.

(120) During production, component and subsystem manufacturing **1106** and system integration **1108** of aircraft **1200** takes place. Thereafter, aircraft **1200** may go through certification and delivery **1110** in order to be placed in service **1112**. While in service **1112** by a customer, aircraft **1200** is scheduled for routine maintenance and service **1114**, which may include modification, reconfiguration, refurbishment, or other maintenance and service.

(121) Each of the processes of aircraft manufacturing and service method **1100** may be performed or carried out by a system integrator, a third party, and/or an operator. In these examples, the operator may be a customer. For the purposes of this description, a system integrator may include, without limitation, any number of aircraft manufacturers and major-system subcontractors; a third party may include, without limitation, any number of vendors, subcontractors, and suppliers; and an operator may be an airline, a leasing company, a military entity, a service organization, and so on.

(122) With reference now to FIG. **12**, an illustration of an aircraft is depicted in which an illustrative embodiment may be implemented. In this example, aircraft **1200** is produced by aircraft manufacturing and service method **1100** of FIG. **11** and may include airframe **1202** with plurality of systems **1204** and interior **1206**. Examples of systems **1204** include one or more of propulsion system **1208**, electrical system **1210**, hydraulic system **1212**, and environmental system **1214**. Any number of other systems may be included.

(123) Apparatuses and methods embodied herein may be employed during at least one of the stages of aircraft manufacturing and service method **1100**. One or more illustrative embodiments may be manufactured or used during at least one of component and subassembly manufacturing **1106**, system integration **1108**, in service **1112**, or maintenance and service **1114** of FIG. **11**.

(124) The illustrative examples fundamentally change the traditional systems engineering V that has been used for decades on complex programs. By pulling specific testing from the far right hand side of the V to the upper left side of the V, critical knowledge is gained regarding the subsystems that are to be integrated, and the design can then be created with much greater quality and safety margins than previously achieved. While the illustrative examples pull activity to the far left, this new process is not prototyping or agile or subsystem qualification or subsystem verification.

(125) The illustrative examples move the interface discovery process to the beginning of the program, prior to design, so the findings can be used to inform the design effort. The illustrative examples allow for a full knowledge base about the new subsystems during the design. Specifically, the illustrative examples perform targeted tests on a new subsystem. These tests are used to finalize detailed interface requirements that then flow into the design.

(126) The illustrative examples involve testing of software, with a virtual module emulating a system, coupled to a subsystem. The illustrative examples include providing input to the virtual module of a command (e.g., initialization) for the subsystem component, and responsively generating, via the virtual module, an output sent via the wiring to the subsystem component.

(127) The illustrative examples determine if there is an inconsistency between the subsystem output and a unique interface control document. The illustrative examples report the detected inconsistency and update or correct the unique interface control document (ICD), if necessary.

(128) In some illustrative examples, the interface control document validation environment consists of five elements: (1) a mechanical rig containing the subsystem (2) electrical wiring that is based on the preliminary design for the subsystem, (3) external non-digital stimulation, such as RF energy or mechanical stimulation, that simulates outside inputs, and (4) a virtual software environment that emulates the behaviors of the integrating hardware/software in accordance with the subsystem-unique interface control document and displays interface data during test, and (5) video and/or digital data recording that may be used post-test to analyze subsystem behavior.

(129) The illustrative examples present interface control document validation tests. The test uses the virtual software environment to initialize the subsystem and command the subsystem. The subsystem receives the commands and reacts to the virtual software environment with status data. The virtual software environment graphically depicts the command and the status digital data. The graphical displays are tailored to support validation of the subsystem's behavior against the system-unique interface control document.

(130) The virtual software environment provides real-time graphical data on a large monitor that can be viewed by multiple operators in a collaborative environment. Real-time data displayed with meaningful graphics, instead of recorded data that must be analyzed post-test, allows the operators to collaboratively assess the system behaviors immediately and adjust the test, as desired. As an added benefit, this element of the virtual software environment can be utilized later, when the full system is brought together for testing.

(131) The illustrative examples provide testing with a virtual module emulating hardware/system-software that is coupled to a subsystem. The illustrative examples provide input to the virtual module of a command (e.g., initialization) for the subsystem component; responsively generate, via the virtual module, an output sent via the wiring to the subsystem component; determine if there is an inconsistency between the subsystem output and a unique ICD; and report the detected inconsistency and updating/correcting the unique ICD if needed. The illustrative examples improve technical quality, leading to cost savings and schedule gains.

(132) The description of the different illustrative embodiments has been presented for purposes of illustration and description, and is not intended to be exhaustive or limited to the embodiments in

the form disclosed. Many modifications and variations will be apparent to those of ordinary skill in the art. Further, different illustrative embodiments may provide different features as compared to other illustrative embodiments. The embodiment or embodiments selected are chosen and described in order to best explain the principles of the embodiments, the practical application, and to enable others of ordinary skill in the art to understand the disclosure for various embodiments with various modifications as are suited to the particular use contemplated.

Claims

1. A testing system configured to test a subsystem prior to completion of a design or assembly into a system, wherein the testing system comprises: a test rig that comprises electrical wiring and a mechanical restraint configured to emulate at least one physical specification of the system and connect the test rig to the subsystem; and a virtual software environment separate from and in communication with the test rig and developed to emulate operating software for subsystems, of the system, planned to interface with the subsystem connected to the test rig, wherein the virtual software environment comprises: a software emulation, of the subsystems of the system planned to interface with the subsystem after the system is built, configured for modification in real time while the subsystem is connected to the test rig; and a hardware emulation, of the subsystems of the system planned to interface with the subsystem after the system is built, configured for modification in real time while the subsystem is connected to the test rig.
2. The testing system of claim 1 further comprising: the software emulation configured to emulate: a timing, an interface data structure, a control algorithm, and display capabilities of software planned for the operating software in the subsystems of the system planned to interface with the subsystem; and a video camera configured to record results of testing the subsystem.
3. The testing system of claim 1 further comprising: an external non-digital stimulator configured to generate a stimulus for the subsystem that comprises an X-ray.
4. The testing system of claim 3, wherein: the subsystems planned to interface with the subsystem are unbuilt; and the external non-digital stimulator is configured to generate RF energy.
5. The testing system of claim 1, wherein the test rig further comprises: kinetic components configured to generate movement of the test rig and subsystem; and thermodynamic components configured to emulate operational thermodynamic conditions of the system, wherein the thermodynamic components are configured to provide thermal management of the subsystem, wherein the thermodynamic components provide heating and cooling to emulate operational conditions of the system, and wherein the thermodynamic components provide heating and cooling to provide thermal management of the subsystem.
6. The testing system of claim 1, wherein the test rig further comprises kinetic components configured to emulate motions of the system while the system is in operation.
7. The testing system of claim 1, wherein the virtual software environment is further configured to provide emulation of at least one element of status data from a component of the system or commands from a component of the system.
8. The testing system of claim 1, wherein the virtual software environment is configured to emulate software logic and algorithms that have not yet been coded in operating software of the subsystems of the system planned to interface with the subsystem.
9. A method of testing a subsystem prior to completing a design or an installation of the subsystem in a system, the method comprising: receiving an interface control document for the subsystem; connecting the subsystem onto a mechanical restraint of a test rig configured to provide mechanical emulation of the system; and performing validation of the interface control document for the subsystem using the test rig and a virtual software environment separate from and communicating with the test rig and emulating software and hardware for the subsystems of the system planned to interface with the subsystem after the system is built, wherein the virtual software environment

comprises: a software emulation, of the subsystems of the system planned to interface with the subsystem, modifiable in real time while the subsystem is connected to the test rig; and a hardware emulation, of the subsystems of the system planned to interface with the subsystem, modifiable in real time while the subsystem is connected to the test rig.

10. The method of claim 9 wherein performing validation of the interface control document comprises: sending commands to the subsystem; evaluating output of the subsystem generated in response to the commands; and determining modifications to the interface control document when the output of the subsystem is inconsistent with the interface control document for the subsystem.

11. The method of claim 10, further comprising: incorporating the modifications into the interface control document to form revised subsystem interface control documents; modifying, using results of testing the subsystem connected to the test rig while the subsystem is connected to the test rig, the virtual software environment emulating the subsystems planned for interfacing with the subsystem after the system is built; and subsequently retesting the subsystem connected to the test rig with a modified virtual software environment.

12. The method of claim 9, further comprising the test rig comprising thermodynamic components emulating operational thermodynamic conditions of the system and providing thermal management of the subsystem, wherein the thermodynamic components provide heating and cooling emulating operational conditions of the system, and wherein the thermodynamic components provide heating and cooling providing thermal management of the subsystem.

13. The method of claim 9 wherein performing validation of the interface control document comprises: providing external stimulation to the subsystem.

14. The method of claim 13, wherein providing external stimulation to the subsystem comprises at least one of: generating RF energy, generating movement of the test rig and subsystem, applying radio waves, and generating an airflow.

15. The method of claim 9, wherein positioning the subsystem onto a test rig configured to provide mechanical emulation of the system comprises: connecting wires from a test rig configured to emulate at least one physical specification of a system to the virtual software environment, wherein connecting the wires from the test rig to the virtual software environment creates a communication connection to the subsystem.

16. The method of claim 9 further comprising: sending stimulation to the subsystem from the virtual software environment, wherein the stimulation emulates input for the subsystem from a physical piece of equipment.

17. The method of claim 9, wherein performing validation comprises performing validation of the interface control document of the subsystem to be used in the system to determine modifications to one of the interface control document or a design for the system, the method further comprising: incorporating the modifications into at least one of the interface control document or a design for the system; and building the system according to the design of the system.

18. The method of claim 17, wherein the modifications comprise changes to physical elements of the system.

19. The method of claim 17, wherein the modifications comprise changes to utilities of the system.

20. The method of claim 17, wherein the modifications comprise changes to software of the system.

21. The method of claim 17, wherein the virtual software environment emulates software for the system and simulates outside inputs to the subsystem.

22. The method of claim 17, wherein the virtual software environment emulates software for the system and simulates electrical wiring of the system.

23. The method of claim 17, wherein performing validation of the interface control document of a subsystem comprises the virtual software environment graphically depicting a command to the subsystem and status data of the subsystem.

24. A method of testing a subsystem prior to completion of a design or an installation in a system,

the method comprising: receiving an interface control document for the subsystem; connecting the subsystem onto a mechanical restraint of a test rig configured to provide mechanical emulation of the system; and performing validation of the interface control document for the subsystem using the test rig and a virtual software environment separate from and in communication with the test rig and emulating software and hardware for the subsystems, of the system planned to interface with the subsystem after the system is built, wherein the virtual software environment comprises: a software emulation, of the subsystems of the system planned to interface with the subsystem, modifiable in real time; and a hardware emulation, of the subsystems of the system planned to interface with the subsystem, modifiable in real time, wherein the test rig comprises thermodynamic components emulating operational thermodynamic conditions of the system, wherein the thermodynamic components are configured to provide thermal management of the subsystem, wherein the thermodynamic components provide heating and cooling to emulate operational conditions of the system, and wherein the thermodynamic components provide heating and cooling to provide thermal management of the subsystem, and wherein performing validation of an interface control document for the subsystem comprises: receiving input at the virtual software environment to generate a command for the subsystem; responsively generating, via the virtual software environment, the command to send to the subsystem; receiving output from the subsystem; and determining if there is an inconsistency between the output from the subsystem and interface control documents of the subsystem; and identifying design changes needed in one of the subsystems of the system emulated interfacing with the subsystem connected to the test rig and suggesting modifications to the virtual software environment for further testing of the subsystem connected to the test rig.

25. The method of claim 24 further comprising: reporting a detected inconsistency; modifying, using results of testing the subsystem connected to the test rig while the subsystem is connected to the test rig, the virtual software environment emulating the subsystems planned for interfacing with the subsystem after the system is built; and subsequently retesting the subsystem connected to the test rig with a modified virtual software environment.

26. The method of claim 25 further comprising: incorporating modifications into the interface control document to form a revised subsystem interface control document based on the inconsistency.

27. The method of claim 24 further comprising: displaying the output to an operator.

28. The method of claim 24 further comprising: recording the output of the subsystem in data storage.

29. The method of claim 24 further comprising: sending the command to the subsystem via wiring connecting the virtual software environment to the subsystem.
